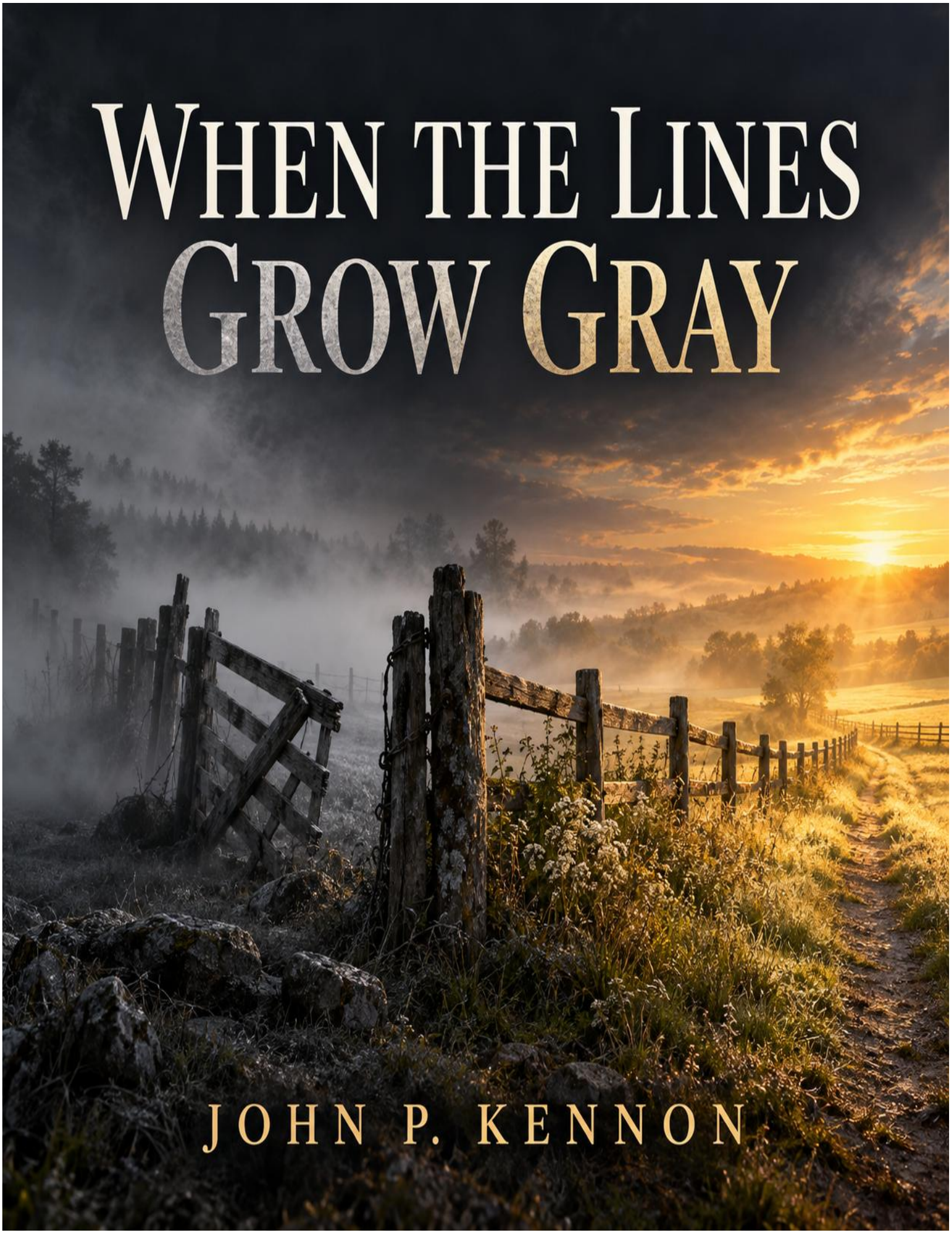

When the Lines Grow Gray
John P. Kennon

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Finding Clarity Through Conviction and Grace in a Confused World

A Teaching Booklet and Audio Lesson

John P. Kennon

Imagine two farms sitting side by side. For generations, a fence has marked the boundary between them. Everyone knows where one field ends and the other begins.

Then one fence post begins to lean. Nobody fixes it. A strand of wire breaks. Cattle begin crossing from one field into the other, and weeds grow around the remaining posts.

At first, everyone still remembers where the boundary belongs. But every season makes it harder to see. Eventually, a new generation inherits those farms. They did not watch the fence deteriorate. They simply grew up with cattle wandering between the fields and weeds covering the property line.

They look across the land and ask, 'Was there ever really a boundary here?'

The boundary did not move. Neglect made it difficult to see.

That is how moral and spiritual confusion often develops. It rarely begins with someone deliberately deciding that good and evil no longer matter. One conviction is ignored. One exception is made. One compromise becomes familiar. What once troubled the conscience becomes tolerated, and what is tolerated long enough begins to feel normal.

A boundary neglected long enough becomes a boundary forgotten.

That is the condition God confronted through Ezekiel in chapter twenty-two. God's people still had the Temple, priests, sacrifices, gatherings and the words of the Law. Outwardly, their religion was still operating. Inwardly, the fence lines had collapsed.

God said the priests had profaned holy things. They no longer put a difference between the holy and the profane, and they no longer showed the people the difference between the unclean and the clean. The people had not lost every religious activity. They had lost the ability to recognize what belonged to God and what did not.

Now bring that picture into our day. The same phone can bring us Scripture, worship and godly teaching, then moments later place violence, lust, bitterness, mockery and confusion before our eyes. Everything enters through the same screen. Everything competes for the same attention. If everything receives the same welcome, everything eventually begins to feel equally ordinary.

If we handle the clean and the unclean together and call them common, confusion has won, because the holy and the profane have become indistinguishable.

This message is not calling us to become religious policemen. We are not being sent to inspect everyone else's field while weeds overtake our own. The question is personal: What is shaping my mind? What is feeding my desires? What have I accepted simply because I have seen it repeatedly? What once troubled my spirit but now feels ordinary?

This is not a message about earning salvation through rules. It is about allowing the grace that saved us to teach us how to live. God does not merely want to place another fence around our behavior. Through the Holy Ghost, He wants to restore discernment within the heart.

When the lines grow gray, confusion begins to feel normal. But God has not left us without light.

Part One The Revelation in Ezekiel

Before we can understand what went wrong in Ezekiel's day, we must understand what God first placed into the hands of the priests. They were not asked to invent religious boundaries. They were entrusted with distinctions God had already established.

Leviticus chapter ten, verses ten and eleven, says:

> *"That ye may put difference between holy and unholy, and between unclean and clean; and that ye may teach the children of Israel all the statutes which the Lord hath spoken unto them by the hand of Moses."*

Four words stand at the center of that command: holy, common, clean, and unclean. Let me name them again. Holy and common form the first distinction. Clean and unclean form the second distinction.

These words are related, but they are not interchangeable. Holy does not simply mean clean. Common does not automatically mean sinful. Clean does not necessarily mean consecrated. Unclean does not always mean morally guilty. So let us take the words one at a time.

First, consider the word holy. The Hebrew word is pronounced KOH-desh. Holy means set apart for God, belonging to Him, or assigned to a sacred purpose. Holiness is about belonging and consecration. Something is holy because it has been separated from ordinary use and devoted to God.

Now place beside holy its contrasting term: common, sometimes translated profane. The Hebrew word is pronounced KHOHL. Common means ordinary, everyday, or available for ordinary use. Common does not automatically mean wicked, corrupt, or sinful. A common thing may be perfectly lawful and clean. It simply has not been set apart for sacred use.

That completes the first pair. Holy and common describe purpose and belonging. Has this been set apart for God, or does it remain available for ordinary use?

Now we come to the second pair: clean and unclean. Begin with clean. The Hebrew word is pronounced tah-HORE. Under the Old Covenant, clean meant fit to approach, participate in worship, or remain within the sacred order of the covenant community. Something could be clean without being holy. It could be lawful and acceptable while still remaining ordinary.

Now place beside clean its contrasting term: unclean. The Hebrew word is pronounced tah-MAY. Unclean meant defiled or temporarily unfit for sacred participation. Uncleanness could involve sin, but it did not always mean personal moral guilt. Childbirth, disease, bodily discharge, or contact with death could make a person ceremonially unclean until the prescribed cleansing or waiting period had been completed.

That completes the second pair. Clean and unclean describe condition and fitness. Is this presently fit to enter the sacred sphere, or must cleansing take place first?

Now gather the four words back together. Holy and common concern purpose and belonging. Clean and unclean concern condition and fitness. A thing could be common and clean. It could be common

and unclean. What had been made holy belonged to God and had to be guarded from profanation. What had become unclean could not be brought into the holy sphere until cleansing had taken place.

That is why the priests needed discernment. They were not merely deciding whether something was good or bad. They had to recognize what belonged to God, what remained ordinary, what was fit to approach, and what required cleansing. They did not create the distinction. They were commanded to recognize it, live beneath it, and teach it faithfully.

Common is not automatically corrupt. The danger begins when what belongs to God is treated as merely ordinary, or when clean and unclean are handled as though the distinction no longer matters.

Keep that responsibility in mind, because it prepares us to hear Ezekiel's indictment. By Ezekiel's time, the problem was not that God had failed to make the distinction clear. The problem was that generations of compromise had made the distinction difficult to see.

Ezekiel was a priest carried into Babylon with King Jehoiachin and many of Judah's leaders in five hundred ninety-seven B.C. Nebuchadnezzar placed Zedekiah on Jerusalem's throne. The Temple remained open, sacrifices continued and priests still wore priestly garments, but Judah was moving toward Jerusalem's destruction in five hundred eighty-seven or five hundred eighty-six B.C.

Ezekiel preached from exile while Jeremiah warned the people in Jerusalem. Ezekiel chapter twenty-two therefore exposes a nation whose religious machinery was still operating even though covenant faithfulness had collapsed. They still had priests, prophets, sacrifices and Sabbaths, but they had lost the distinction that gave those practices meaning.

The road began long before Ezekiel, and one of its darkest stretches came under King Manasseh.

Manasseh ruled Judah for fifty-five years. Second Kings chapter twenty-one records that he rebuilt pagan high places, erected altars to Baal, worshiped the host of heaven, practiced occultism, sacrificed his son, placed pagan objects within the Temple complex and filled Jerusalem with innocent blood. Idolatry was no longer private. It entered the institutions of the nation and stood beside the worship of Jehovah.

A generation grew up seeing pagan worship beside the worship of Jehovah. What should have been unthinkable became visible, familiar, and eventually normal. Then Josiah came to the throne and called the nation back to God.

Josiah found the neglected Book of the Law, destroyed idols, cleansed the Temple and restored Passover. The reform was genuine, but it could not force every heart to change. Jeremiah chapter three, verse ten says Judah did not return with her whole heart. Some surrendered their idols; others merely hid them. After Josiah died in six hundred nine B.C., the nation quickly returned to its former appetites.

Jehoiakim and the rulers who followed used power for oppression and personal gain. Jeremiah condemned luxury built through unpaid labor, innocent bloodshed and violence. Judah shifted political loyalties between Egypt and Babylon, resisted prophetic warnings and finally rebelled against Babylon. Leadership no longer protected covenant life. It exploited the people and resisted correction.

The prophets should have confronted the collapse. Instead, Ezekiel said they whitewashed it with false visions and claimed God had spoken when He had not. They promised peace without repentance and restoration without surrender. They did more than ignore sin. They placed religious language over it and made rebellion sound faithful.

By then Judah did not lack religion. It lacked truthfulness. The nation still knew how to sound spiritual while living around the demands of God. To feel how compromise moves from one generation to the next, imagine a priestly family living through those years.

This family is an illustration built from the history recorded in Scripture. It is not a named family in the biblical text.

Imagine three generations of a priestly family living in Jerusalem.

The grandfather served during Manasseh's reign. He watched pagan altars rise within the courts of the Lord's house. At first, the mixture disturbed him. He knew the Temple was holy and the idols were unclean. But the king had power, the people approved and speaking carried a price. He did not tear the Law from the scroll. He simply stopped declaring what it said.

His son grew up surrounded by mixture. What shocked the father became familiar to the child. Then Josiah became king. The Book of the Law was found, the Temple was cleansed and the idols were broken down. The young man entered the priesthood during revival. Yet Josiah could remove idols from public view without removing them from every heart. Some people obeyed the reform without embracing its revelation.

After Josiah died, the third generation entered the priesthood. The Temple remained open and sacrifices continued, but the distinctions had weakened. A wealthy man offered a gift and the priest overlooked what the Law required. A ruler oppressed a poor family and the priest remained silent. A false prophet promised peace and the priest accepted the easier message. The Sabbath became inconvenient, holy things became familiar and practices once called unclean were tolerated because everyone was doing them.

No council announced that the holy and common would now be treated alike. It happened quietly. One compromise became an exception. The exception became an accommodation. The accommodation became a custom. The custom became a culture. Eventually the priests could no longer see clearly what God had always distinguished.

Ezekiel calls Jerusalem the bloody city. He names idolatry and the shedding of innocent blood. He names contempt for fathers and mothers, oppression of foreigners, widows and orphans, disregard for holy things and Sabbaths, slander, sexual immorality, bribery, dishonest profit, abuse of power, false prophecy, and forgetfulness of God.

The corruption touched princes, priests, prophets, officials and ordinary people. Every institution that should have restrained the collapse had become part of it.

Now we can hear the force of the question. How could the priests teach a distinction they had stopped honoring in their own lives?

Ezekiel chapter twenty-two, verse twenty-six, says:

> *"Her priests have violated my law, and have profaned mine holy things: they have put no difference between the holy and profane, neither have they shewed difference between the*

> *unclean and the clean, and have hid their eyes from my sabbaths, and I am profaned among them."*

The order of the verse matters. They violated the Law, profaned holy things, stopped distinguishing, stopped teaching and deliberately closed their eyes. Their problem was not lack of information. Leviticus still said what it had always said. Their problem was compromised discernment.

To teach the distinction clearly, the priests would have needed to confront their own practices, powerful rulers, popular prophets and a religious system that benefited them. They were unwilling before they became unable. Repeated compromise clouded the teacher's own vision.

What they tolerated, they normalized. What they normalized, they stopped confronting. What they stopped confronting, they eventually lost the ability to discern.

Read beyond verse twenty-six and the damage comes into view. In Ezekiel chapter twenty-two, verses twenty-five through twenty-nine, predatory prophets devour lives, princes pursue dishonest gain, and the people practice oppression and robbery. The poor, the needy, and the stranger bear the cost. The priests did not create every sin named in the chapter, but by violating the Law and hiding their eyes, they failed to teach the difference when the people most needed light.

A broken fence does not harm only the person who left the gate open. When the watchmen stop watching, the whole field becomes vulnerable.

When the Lines Became Broken Walls

There is an old farmer’s saying: “If any ol’ way will do, then no way will do just as well.” That is more than country wit. It describes what happens when every boundary is treated as optional and every direction is given equal authority. If every road is declared equally safe, direction eventually means nothing. If every voice is treated as equally true, truth eventually becomes unnecessary.

Josephus helps us follow Ezekiel chapter twenty-two from spiritual diagnosis into historical consequence. In Antiquities of the Jews, Book Ten, chapters seven through nine, he retells the final years of Judah, the fall of Jerusalem and the Babylonian captivity. Josephus wrote centuries after these events and was not an eyewitness to them. His account largely gathers and interprets the history preserved in Scripture. We should therefore use him as an ancient Jewish historical retelling, not as a contemporary reporter standing inside Jerusalem.

Josephus describes Zedekiah as a ruler who neglected justice and duty. Corrupt counselors surrounded him, false prophets reassured him and the people increasingly did what seemed right in their own eyes. Jeremiah continued to call the king away from transgression and back to what was right. According to Josephus, Zedekiah could recognize that Jeremiah’s counsel was true and beneficial, but he allowed his friends and rulers to turn him away from it.

Zedekiah did not lack revelation. He lacked the courage to obey what he recognized.

That is an important stage in the collapse of discernment. Truth may remain visible long after obedience has weakened. A person can agree with truth privately and still surrender to pressure publicly. When approval from the crowd carries more weight than the Word of God, the line has already begun to move within the heart.

Josephus then records a detail that reaches directly into this lesson. Jeremiah warned that Zedekiah would be taken to Babylon and would stand before its king. Josephus understood Ezekiel to say that Zedekiah would not see Babylon. Instead of listening to the warning upon which both prophets agreed, Zedekiah focused upon what appeared to him to be a contradiction. Because he could not reconcile one detail, he dismissed the message they shared: Jerusalem would fall, and he would be captured.

The apparent contradiction was resolved in the event. Zedekiah was captured and brought face-to-face with Nebuchadnezzar. His sons were killed before him. Then his eyes were put out, and he was carried to Babylon. Jeremiah's warning was fulfilled because Zedekiah was taken there. Ezekiel's warning was fulfilled because the blinded king never saw it.

Zedekiah used what he could not reconcile as permission to disregard what God had made unmistakably clear.

People can still fall into that trap. We may find one difficult passage, one disagreement among teachers or one question we cannot immediately resolve and use it to dismiss everything Scripture says plainly. A farmer would say, "Do not ignore the storm because two men disagree about which cloud is carrying the rain." Humility keeps studying, keeps praying and keeps obeying the light it has already received.

Josephus also describes how false prophets interpreted temporary relief as permanent deliverance. When Babylon briefly withdrew to confront the Egyptian army, they announced that the danger was over. They promised that Babylon would not return and that the captives and Temple vessels would soon come home. Jeremiah declared that the army would return, the siege would resume, famine would follow and the city and Temple would be destroyed. The easier message required no repentance, so it sounded more attractive.

Once people stop distinguishing truth from preference, they begin calling whatever comforts them the word of God.

The consequences were not theoretical. Josephus says Jerusalem endured an eighteen-month siege. Famine and disease weakened the people. The city was captured, Zedekiah's family was destroyed, the Temple was plundered and burned, Jerusalem was leveled, leaders and priests were executed, and the survivors were carried into Babylon. What began as an unwillingness to honor God's distinctions ended with the collapse of the institutions that had been entrusted to preserve them.

What began with priests refusing to declare the line ended with an enemy tearing down the wall.

The damage continued after Jerusalem fell. Gedaliah was appointed over those who remained, but he was murdered. Fear and distrust scattered the remnant again, and some fled toward Egypt even after being warned not to place their confidence there. Confusion did not merely produce one bad decision. It trained a generation to distrust correction and keep reaching for another way.

Yet judgment was not the end of the story. Josephus goes on to describe Cyrus permitting the Jewish people to return to their land, rebuild Jerusalem and restore the Temple. The sacred vessels taken by

Nebuchadnezzar were sent back, and the work was eventually completed under Darius. God did not restore His people by pretending the collapse had never happened. He brought them back, restored worship and gave them another opportunity to live as His covenant people.

Human confusion tore down the distinctions, but divine mercy did not abandon the people.

Josephus records a sobering later echo in The Jewish War. Centuries after the Babylonian destruction, during Jerusalem's fall to Rome, false prophets again promised miraculous deliverance while destruction was overtaking the city. That later event is not the direct continuation of Ezekiel chapter twenty-two, but the repeated pattern is difficult to miss: when people reject an uncomfortable truth long enough, they become vulnerable to a comforting lie.

Ezekiel declared what was happening spiritually. Josephus describes what that spiritual confusion eventually produced historically. "If any ol' way will do, then no way will do just as well." Jerusalem discovered that when every voice was permitted to move the line, the people eventually lost the road, the wall, the city and the Temple. But God, in mercy, reached into their captivity and began rebuilding what confusion had destroyed.

Now bring that picture into our own day. People encounter many philosophies, religions and ways of explaining Christian faith. A sincere seeker can feel overwhelmed by so many voices. Ezekiel's question presses upon us as teachers: are we giving people enough light to recognize what God has said, or have we let the lines grow gray in our own lives?

But God is not confused. Ephesians chapter four declares, "One Lord, one faith, one baptism," and continues, "One God and Father of all." God is one, and His gospel is not a thousand different messages. Paul warned the Galatians against altering the gospel they had received. We hold fast to the revelation of Jesus Christ and proclaim His gospel faithfully, with love for every person listening.

Psalm one hundred nineteen, verse eighty-nine, says, "For ever, O Lord, thy word is settled in heaven." The gospel stands upon that enduring Word. A farmer who finds conflicting signs at the edge of his field returns to the true marker. So we return to Scripture and ask the Holy Ghost to search our own hearts first. Then we can speak with clarity, humility and compassion.

The field may be crowded with voices, but God's Word has not moved.

Compromise does not only dull discernment. After people have lived in confusion for a long time, clarity itself can begin to feel threatening.

There is another reason people may resist distinction. For some, chaos has become familiar. It may be painful, but it is known. It has become camouflage, comfort or even a place of control. The moment truth brings structure and godly order into that chaos, the person may feel exposed and run from the very clarity that could help them.

When chaos has become familiar, godly order can feel like oppression. The boundary is not necessarily the enemy; sometimes it simply reveals what disorder has been protecting.

Some people do not run because truth is unclear. They run because truth brings definition, and definition requires a decision. That is what happened in Judah. The Law had not disappeared. The people had learned to live around it until mixture felt normal and clarity felt disruptive.

This does not give us permission to become harsh or controlling. Godly order carried through human pride can become legalistic pressure. But neither can we rename confusion as grace merely because clarity makes someone uncomfortable. Truth and love must travel together. Truth gives definition; love gives people room to respond.

When light enters chaos, some receive clarity. Others retreat because confusion gave them somewhere to hide. Our responsibility is to keep the light clean, keep our spirit humble and allow the Holy Ghost to do what pressure never can.

Ezekiel chapter twenty-two ends with judgment, not a quick escape from consequences. God sought someone to stand in the gap for the land, and the chapter says He found none. Jerusalem could not repair its own breach. Yet that is not the end of Ezekiel. In chapter thirty-four, God confronts the shepherds who fed themselves while the flock scattered. Then He says He Himself will seek His sheep. In chapter thirty-six, He promises to cleanse His people, give them a new heart, and put His Spirit within them. The God who exposed the breach also promised to reach for the people caught in it. How would that inward restoration come? The Old Covenant points us toward Jesus Christ.

Part Two The New Covenant Within Us

The answer is the New Covenant. God would not abandon His holiness or erase the distinction. He would bring His law within us and give us His Spirit. The Old Covenant therefore points us directly to Jesus Christ.

The Old Testament was not God's failed attempt to make humanity righteous. The Law accomplished exactly what God intended it to accomplish. Paul called it “our schoolmaster to bring us unto Christ” because it revealed God's holiness, defined righteousness and exposed humanity's inability to become righteous through human effort alone.

Jesus taught that the entire Law rests upon two great commandments: love God with all the heart, soul and mind, and love your neighbor as yourself. The standard was righteous, but fallen humanity could not produce that love merely because it had been commanded. The Law could tell humanity what love required, but it could not create the inward nature from which that love flows.

Romans brings the whole world into the courtroom and declares every person guilty before God. The religious and irreligious, Jew and Gentile, moral and immoral all stand in need of grace. The Law did not create our sinful condition; it revealed it. It could identify the wound, but it could not become the cure.

Romans chapter three, verse twenty, says:

> *"Therefore by the deeds of the law there shall no flesh be justified in his sight: for by the law is the knowledge of sin."*

God was not surprised by humanity's failure, nor was the New Covenant an emergency repair. Before the foundation of the world, God's redemptive purpose pointed toward Jesus Christ. The Old Covenant prepared the way by showing us what righteousness required and why we could never produce it through self-will.

Jesus then declared that a branch cannot bear fruit by itself. It must abide in the vine. In the same way, we cannot manufacture spiritual life through observation, discipline or outward conformity. We

End of sample

Thank you for reading the opening of When the Lines Grow Gray.

The full edition is being prepared for publication.

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